

Vertigo



Dawn cloud spills over Sawtooth Ridge, channelled by Tiraha (1,668m), where this shot is taken and Ohuinga (1,686m) on the far side, Ruahines - photo by Peter Laurenson

Section News

Section Nights

We have the NZAC's president, Penny Brothers, speaking at our March section night. We will be kicking off at 6pm on 1 March at the Southern Cross on Abel Smith Street.

"Twin summits - highs and lows of a bifurcated climbing career" by Penny Brothers

Penny will talk a bit about climbing in the 70s and 80s (as a young thing) in NZ, USA and the Himalayas and then returning to climbing in the 2000s after a break tending career and family. Recent highs and lows are more in the "mild things" category - Aspiring, Cook, Olivines, trekking in Nepal, skiing in Norway and rafting the Grand Canyon (this is the "low" since she went down the canyon). Penny will finish up with a brief picture of her view of where NZAC is at the moment and where it's going, particularly as a result of the current strategic planning process.

Please don't forget the koha for section night – there'll be an ice bucket at the entry door for that purpose. ☺

Vertigo

We're always keen to have content from our section members in Vertigo. If you have any cool (portait) photos that can be used for the cover shot or any reports on trips you've done please send them through to Carolyn at kaz1963@gmail.com. The following is the schedule for Vertigo for the next few months:

Closing date for submissions	Publish date
24 March 2017	30 March 2017
21 April 2017	27 April 2017
19 May 2017	25 May 2017
23 June 2017	29 June 2017

Chairs Report February 2017

Water quality, Yeah Right! Or should that be Pigs arse?

The Government has set a target of making 90 per cent of **New Zealand's** rivers and streams safe for swimming by **2040**.

I liked freshwater ecologist Dr Mike Joy's remarks on the government's approach to 'cleaning up' our waterways so that where there is a 1 in 20 chance of getting sick this is now defined as excellent water quality.

I don't want to swim in it, I want to be able to drink it.

Mike apparently stated that "It's like saying 'OK, a lot of people are exceeding the 50 km/h speed limit in town so, in 20 years' time, we're going to have 90 percent of the people obeying the rules - but we're going to shift the speed limit to 100km/h"

Does Minister Smith really think a 1 in 20 chance of getting campylobacter swimming in a river is going to attract tourists. Maybe he thinks we should just drink Perrier instead. Clean water isn't just about making money. If that is the benchmark for quality of life what will be next? Air quality?

If you have any comments on what you liked or didn't like send an email to wellington@alpineclub.org.nz or tweet us @NZACWellington or post a message on our facebook page www.facebook.com/nzacwellington.

Finally:

Water and air, the two essential fluids on which all life depends, have become global garbage cans.
Jacques Yves Cousteau

Chair: Simon Williamson
NZAC Wellington

For quick access to the section's page on the NZAC website, scan the below QR code.



Gear Hire

Don't forget the section has gear for hire : avalanche transceivers, ice axes, shovels, stakes, hammers, helmets, crampons, probes and PLBs. If you're keen to hire some gear please fill in the form [here](#). Each item costs \$5 per week with the exception of PLBs – PLBs are free but require a deposit of \$50 refundable on its return. The section is continuing to upgrade gear with new helmets, crampons and a couple of entry level ice hammers among the more recent purchases.

A little bit of advance notice would be appreciated as gear often needs to be retrieved from the gear store in Lower Hutt. Gear collections and drop-offs are usually available in the city during the working day or at section night.

Upcoming Trips, Courses and Events

Wellington Section Trips and Courses

All our planned South Island trips come with the added bonus that rental vehicle costs are covered by the section. If you're uncertain about the skill level required with any of the trips, would like to register your interest or know more email us on wellington@alpineclub.org.nz.

Also, please contact us if you're keen to run a trip yourself – the committee can help with advertising / logistics.

When?	Where?
11-13 March	Paynes Ford, rock climbing – led by Eric Duggan
Easter	Mt Kensington, West Coast – details to be confirmed
21-23 July	Beginner level Snowcraft course – Mt Ruapehu
28-30 July	Beginner level Snowcraft course – Mt Ruapehu
18-20 August	Beginner / Intermediate level Snowcraft course – Mt Ruapehu
25-27 August	Intermediate / Advanced level Snowcraft course – Mt Ruapehu

Application forms for our 2017 Snowcraft courses on Ruapehu will be made available soon so keep an eye on our Facebook page and your email.

Outdoor Training NZ Courses

OTNZ Wellington are running training courses as follows:

- Navigation (one evening of theory on 27 February and one field day on 5 March) - \$50
- Introductory bushcraft (24-26 March) - \$60
- Intermediate bushcraft (24-26 February) - \$80
- Advanced bushcraft (5-7 May) - \$100
- Risk Management (24-25 June) - \$70

More information on these courses and how to book your place can be found on <http://www.outdoortraining.nz/courses/courses.php>.

Trip Reports

Instructor Development Course – December 2016

Written by Richard Young

Last December an impromptu opportunity arose for NZAC to offer a development course to those who had assisted on the annual Snowcraft courses run by regional branches. The course would be conducted by Nick Craddock, limited to four participants and first in first serve. It sounded like a great idea and, being in a position to mobilise quickly, I put my hand up. It turned out the other participants weren't able to make it after all and after a bit of discussion about whether we should proceed or not, it was decided I would still join Nick for some climbing and development.

Upon arrival in Queenstown I sorted out the minor problem of my gear being sent to Auckland instead of Queenstown and after ensuring that Air NZ would guarantee delivery of my gear to Unwin I left for Mt Cook Village to meet Nick.

When I arrived we made a plan for the morning. The weather was looking good for a few days and we discussed going to Plateau for some technical training and possibly climbing Dixon. A flight to Plateau Hut was booked for 9am. The following morning we had breakfast, did a gear sort (my gear arrived at 10pm the night before - hats off to Air NZ), and made our way down to the airport.

Arrival at Plateau Hut on a balmy windless day was fantastic and I was pleased to be in the mountains again. We claimed our bunks, had a bite to eat and set off towards Mt Dixon and the purpose of the afternoon's exercise was to climb a circuit Nick often uses for teaching courses. Nick explained how the benefit of knowing your terrain and when it was coming up is highly valuable when taking students, particularly when conditions aren't ideal but leaving plenty of options open. Our circuit involved climbing up to the East Ridge of Mt Dixon from the Grand Plateau, practicing placing gear, and establishing belay stations along the way. We then traversed the ridgeline back towards Plateau Hut and rapped back down to the Grand Plateau to head back to the hut for a brew.



Grand Plateau / Mt Dixon

The plan for Day two was in a state of flux for a few hours because our weather window was rapidly diminishing. Several other parties in the hut had bailed from other objectives like Aspiring and Cook and were now lining up Mt Dixon as their next target. Knowing it was going to be rather crowded and probably average conditions we set the alarm for 4am for a potential start on Dixon. Already awake with the general activity of the hut we didn't need the alarm and got up to check the weather ala "look out the window.com" and it confirmed how it sounded from inside, strong winds and snowing. Not pleasant. Nick and I quickly decided that wasn't for us and we could make better use of our limited time that day so we headed back to bed for a couple of hours. We would aim to climb the lower buttress on the South Ridge of Dixon instead. It would be more technical climbing and more enjoyable conditions and it proved to be exactly that. After a bit of effort crossing the large schrund we climbed to the top of the lower buttress, had a couple of stops to check some belay stations for future training, then rapped off and headed back to the hut.

The weather wasn't looking good for the next day and all parties were preparing for a mass exodus the next morning. We were preparing for the same but Nick miraculously managed to arrange a shared flight arriving in 30 minutes so it was all go to get packed and ready for the machine to pick us up. Within an hour we were back at Unwin showered and eating venison steaks for tea!

The rest of the week at Mt Cook was looking like our current summer – windy, cloudy and slightly wet. The next day we decided to climb some of the classic multi-pitch trad routes at Sebastipol

which was excellent. Nick showed me a new teaching area ear marked for development and we did a bit of route cleaning while we were there.

We finished off our time at Unwin the following morning with some technical rope work, crevasse rescue, escaping the system, pussiking and confidence roping.

The weather was still looking unsettled and we decided to head to Wanaka but postpone our last day together to avoid the passing cold front. When we met for our last day together the plan was to head over to the Remarkables to do the traverse but the 30cm of overnight snowfall stopped that plan dead in it's tracks and we opted for a second breakfast at Kai Whakapai and more trad climbing at Hospital Flat. It was hard to believe we couldn't stick to our original plan because of too much snow considering we were trad climbing in hot sunny conditions with temperatures in the mid 20s that same day!

Nick said the whole of spring and early summer was so unsettled that the season had basically been like one big storm up to mid December. Despite the mixed bag of weather for this trip we maximised our time as best as possible practicing some technical climbing skills and learning some useful tricks of the trade when assisting on the section snowcraft courses. The trip was well worthwhile, and thanks to Nick Craddock, Simon Middlemass, Simon Williamson and the Wellington section for supporting it.

The four day horse shoe

Words and photos Peter Laurenson

It's not been a summer to remember weather-wise. Clear spells have been short and hard to predict. I'd hoped to get down to the main divide again at some point over the summer break, but it just wasn't a happening thing for me on weather or climbing buddy fronts. So when I got an invitation to join Shaun Barnett and a friend of his, Joe Nawalaniec, to head onto the Ruahine's tops for four days I figured North Island is better than no island. Besides, Shaun is one of New Zealand's most renowned and successful back country photographers and writers – a man I aspire to. He also has a few decades of back country experience and an encyclopaedic knowledge of our high places. I might not be on the main divide but I would surely learn some things from him on the trail. And his mate Joe, while not so into photography, also has done more horizontal and vertical miles in the hills than my joints care to contemplate. During the four days I spent with them it seemed that, between them, there wasn't much left anywhere between 500m and 2,500m in New Zealand that they hadn't been.



Yarning with Richard and his dogs

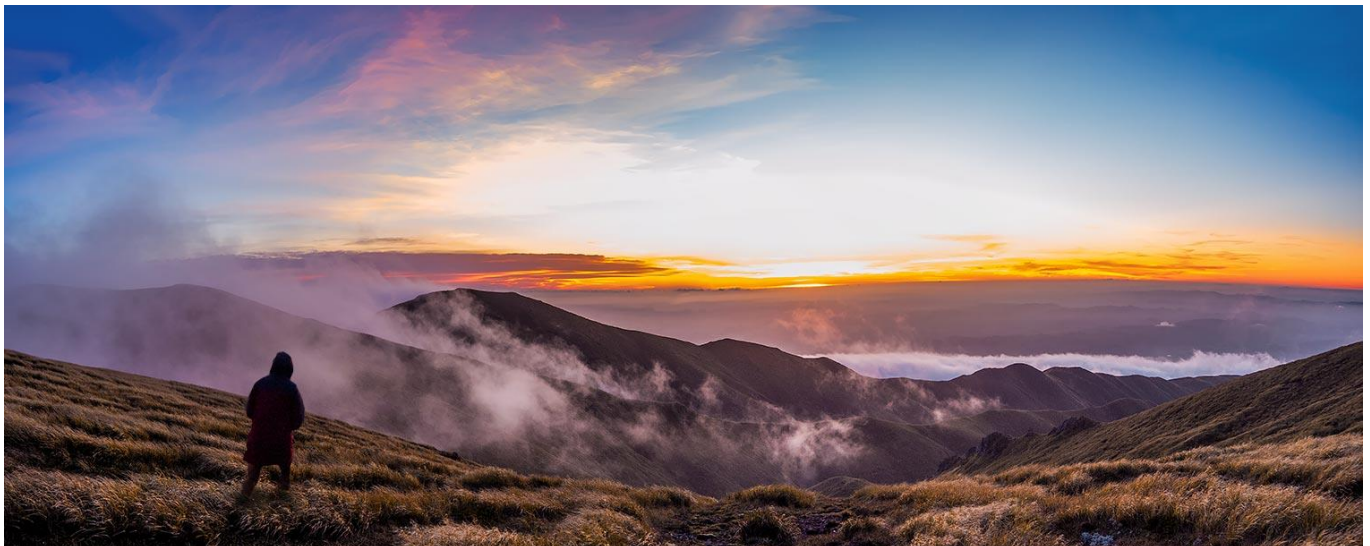
Our trip into the Ruahines was Shaun's plan D, which we chose due to the weather looking most settled north of the Tararuas. Our route started at the Mangakukeke Road end, which is surrounded by private farmland. Beforehand I called ahead to secure our permission to pass across the farms to gain access to both Purity Hut, our way in (call Richard Gorringer 06 382 5856); and Kelly Knight Hut, our way out (call Colin Thompson 06 382 5577). Beyond these two huts we would spend most of our time above 1,500 metres on an expansive horseshoe-shaped route that took us over many of the highest points in the Ruahines, from the west to the east and back again. The whole trip, including a side trip over Mangaweka on the first evening, only amounted to about 37 horizontal kms. But it also involved nearly three vertical kms of ascent and descent. For me the beauty lay in being on the tops for all but a couple of hours on the first and last days, and being able to camp out under the stars for three consecutive nights.

On Day One we set off across Richard's farmland about 11am and soon met the man himself, plus an impressive team of dogs, up on the ridge leading to the forest park, at about 800m. Richard has a bit of a reputation for being pretty blunt about access permissions. He's suffered frustrations, like loss of stock due to trampers passing through over the years. This has hardened his approach. But the two times I've needed to pass over his farm he's been helpful and very happy to have a yarn, which we did this time, while wiping sweat from our brows. It was sunny and humid and the access ridge is steep.



Purity Hut

Once into the forest it's only another hour or so to Purity Hut, which affords panoramic views out to Mount Ruapehu. Our destination for the evening was Iron Peg, but we had plenty of time, so hung out in the sun on the hut's deck while Joe and I got to know one another a bit better. It was already apparent that I had a serious back country enthusiast as company – not just in New Zealand but in many other mountainous areas like Ladakh, where he leads trips up 6,000m plus peaks, among many other outdoor pursuits. And Joe can definitely not be accused of conservatism. We were set for many good discussions with this maverick devil's advocate over the next few days.



Sunset from near the broad flat summit of Mangaweka (1,731m) – highest point in the Ruahines

The route up to Iron peg at 1,703m is very straight forward, lulling us into a false sense of comfort. However, as we progressed higher, so the wind intensified. By several tarns near Iron peg, where we strung up our tent and fly, we battled with fast moving cloud swirling about us. After dinner Joe and I sauntered off along the Hikurangi Range to tag Mangaweka and the next high point along, while Shaun wrote in his journal. Through breaks in the cloud we enjoyed a blood red sunset.



Our campsite at dawn near Iron Peg

It was actually a lot colder than we'd expected overnight, but dawn on Day Two was a photographers dream. Shaun and I were like pigs in warm mud. A fantastic lenticular dome hovered overhead, catching the sun's dawn rays in its alien-like, concave underbelly. Soon though we were back in the murk as cloud again swamped us. This is how it remained as we undulated along the ridge dropping off Iron Peg in a south easterly direction. A little under 6kms away and about 550m of ups and downs lay Ohuinga (1,686m). By the time we reached Ohuinga the weather was clearing, revealing a north end-on, foreshortened view of Sawtooth Ridge. It didn't look far but 3km and another 300m or so of ups and downs meant we were glad to reach the top of Tiraha (1,668m) at the far end. The wind still howled so Shaun and I dropped off the west side of Tiraha in search of a sheltered bivvy spot on the eastern side of the saddle at 1600m. Joe, while never running out of energy, wasn't keen on another cold night, so he opted for a 300m drop down to Howletts Hut on the Daphne Ridge. There he could read his newspaper and then charge on up to re-join us after breakfast next morning.



The view from Ohuinga, along Sawtooth Ridge to Tiraha, then around to Te Hekenga. The Hawkes Bay is in the distance

As photographers, Shaun and I made the right choice. The night was not as cold and, in my bivvy bag, I marvelled at the night sky, clear and spray painted silver with galaxies of stars. Dawn on Day Three was another stunner and the weather had noticeably improved, boding well for the challenges of the day ahead. On top of Tiraha, we shot frame after frame of a huge catchment of cloud, channelled between Ohuinga and Tiraha so it spilled, in slow motion, over Sawtooth Ridge. Ruapehu hovered above the cloud in the distance as the whole magnificent spectacle took on the changing colours of sunrise.



Dawn view from Tiraha, with cloud spilling over Sawtooth Ridge. Ruapehu hovers on the skyline

Soon Joe was back with us and we set off south westerly at first, over Taumataemekura (1,682m). Joe became our supermodel, going back and forth while reflected, mirror-like in various tarns. Due to the high rainfall this summer season we came upon scores of tarns along the route, making the mud a bit warmer still for the camera pigs.

However, we did have something on our minds that kept us a tad on edge. Our crux was fast approaching – a cheval near the summit of Te Hekenga that Richard had warned us about. We'd seen Te Hekenga from various angles the day before and it had looked somewhat gnarly. Now, as we got close, it seemed to alternate between "yeah nah, no worries" and "hmmmm".



Joe on Te Hekenga's cheval. The Cheval Kid is born

At the base of the steep craggy section leading up to the cheval a trail branched off around the base of Te Hekenga on the southern side. The climbing option did look rather intimidating and Shaun decided that there was no good reason to ignore a perfectly good trail. Joe on the other hand was bursting at the seams to get onto the cheval, also insisting that we approach it in good style over the true ridge, rather than taking any soft sidling options.

So, up we went, both hands required. After a steep scramble of about 50m we reached a small platform, beyond which was our crux – a very narrow, exposed, eroded and broken section of no more than 15 metres. With our packs on and no rope, our resolve started to dissolve. But Joe took off his pack and tentatively ventured out, confirming that indeed it was dodgy ground. Once back beside me he suggested I go out for a 'been there' photo op. To my surprise, once out there I could see a feasible way across and said as much. And lo, the Cheval Kid was born. Joe perked up and soon crossed the cheval without his pack to see if the going was any better around the bluff

on the far side. In a moment a huge smile reappeared confirming that “Thunderbirds are go, with packs.”



Crossing the cheval, between the two narrowest sections. Tiraha is on the right skyline and Sawtooth Ridge stretches left

Getting across unprotected was at the edge of my comfort zone. Afterwards, on the summit of Te Hekenga, where Shaun had come around and up to meet us, my vastly more knowledgeable partners agreed that the cheval was the gnarliest section they'd encountered on any non-volcanic terrain in the North Island. That made me feel better. Then, for the next half hour or so Shaun and I watched the Cheval Kid venture back and forth across his narrow, crumbly pathway of joy. The adventure junky claimed it was so we could get a few action shots – a line for the next Tuis ad.

With our crux behind us we still had some work to do before Day Three was done. Also, Joe had never been to Pourangaki Hut, which sat a thousand metres below us and directly accessible down a secondary ridge dropping north off the main ridge between Te Hekenga and the next high point along – Maungamahue (1,661m). So at this point we stopped for lunch before Joe headed down and Shaun and I continued westwards.

The day was clear and calm. And HOT. Beneath Maungamahue we came upon two crystal clear tarns which were too inviting to go past. So after a cooling dip, with replenished water bottles, we plodded up on to Maungamahue to enjoy an expansive view taking in virtually our entire route. From this south westerly aspect it looked big and impressive. And our intended campsite – a tarn at 1,440m, was under 3kms and 250m of descent away. Life was wearisome but good.



Shaun at the tarn beneath Maungamahue

"Oh no, that's not good news". Shaun had just discovered, as we crashed our way through waist-high tussock and spaniards, that the levy was dry. Ironical it was that, after passing so many brimming tarns, the one we needed to be full was empty. Shaun's theory was that the luxuriant tussock all around the tarn had drained it. He was actually able to extract half a litre of water by digging a hole beneath one of the tussocks, all of which sat bedded in quite soggy ground. Too arduous to stay and camp though, so only one thing for it, plod on down to Kelly Knight Hut a further 600 metres below us.

At about 1,200 metres, as we resignedly descended Shaun suddenly piped up "That's weird, I can hear trickling". Indeed he had and soon, just before sunset, we'd strung up our fly right across the trail beside a tiny babbling brook on the ridge. It was a lovely way to finish the day. We even had a picture postcard view out across the lowlands to Mount Ruapehu. Our water supply was sweet and so was life. The only thing missing was the Cheval Kid, who was down at Kelly Knight Hut indulging in social intercourse with two young hunters.



Our sunset view from camp, end of Day 3

Day Four again dawned fine. After a good sleep, a leisurely breakfast and pack up we set off, knowing that it was less than 9kms to the car and mostly downhill. At about 900m there was a sudden odd grunting noise coming from behind us in the bushes. A wild pig surely not! No, it was Joe, fossicking in the shadows in search of another cheval. We all descended to Kelly Knight Hut, swapping details of our split adventures. Joe collected his pack and we headed on out. The last couple of hours were through native forest tracing the Pourangaki River and then across Colin Thompson's farm. We'd shared a fantastic journey and all felt chuffed at connecting with kindred spirits. Joe and I picked Shaun's author, editor and publisher brain, discussing potential book projects. But that's another story, or stories – hopefully ...



On the trail above Pourangaki River and Kelly Knight Hut

For more <http://www.occasionalclimber.co.nz/?p=11918>

Notices

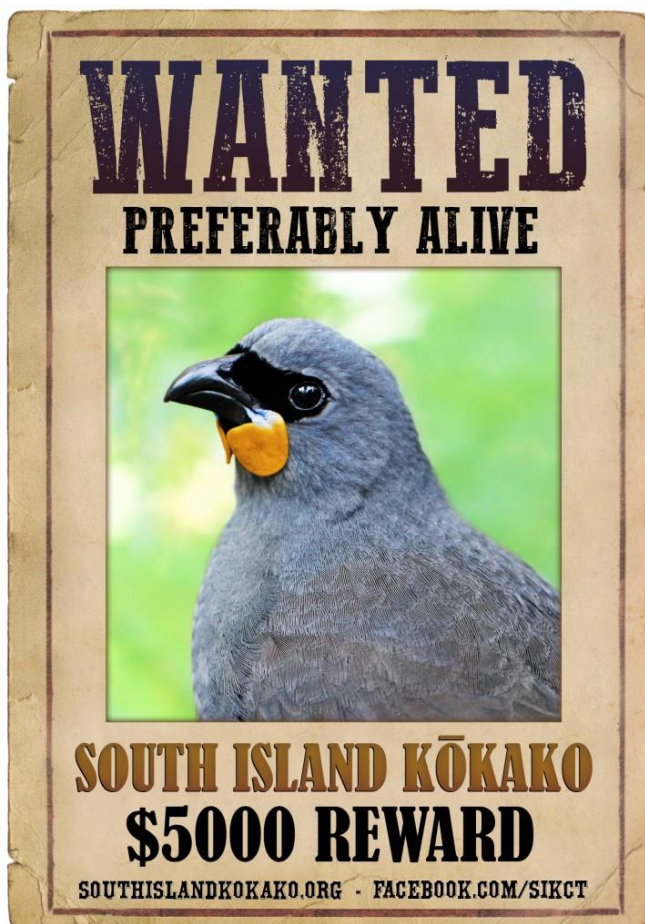
Hut and Tracks Fund: FMC advise applications are now open

In a big vote of confidence the Outdoor Recreation Consortium was recently granted its 3rd year of funding. Another \$400,000 will go to backcountry projects led by volunteers, bringing the total to \$1.6 million.

Applications for the next round of funding are now open, and close on April the 14th. Think about what you might like to contribute to our hut and track network, and if you need advice call your local DOC Office or FMC Executive Officer Jamie Stewart, 027 7674064. If there is one defining feeling from the over 100 projects we have supported to date, it's that every individual or club involved is left immensely satisfied and fulfilled with what they have been able to contribute.

Please find Application Forms, Guidelines and further information to assist in your project planning on the Huts and Tracks website: Click here <http://bit.ly/2kBUd71>

Search for the South Island Kokako



The South Island Kokako Charitable Trust is offering a reward of NZ\$5,000 for information leading to confirmation that the South Island kokako is still alive and we need your help to spread the message.

South Island backcountry enthusiasts will no doubt know that the South Island kokako is an ancient bird once widespread in southern New Zealand forests. It was listed as extinct until 2013 when its status was reclassified as 'data deficient' following credible sightings and it is likely to be the rarest bird on the planet. The reclassification gave the Trust renewed hope and energy to continue the search for this melodious and secretive bird and we're asking for help from you and your members.

The search is urgent. If South Island kokako still exist there will be very few left and they

need to be found and conserved appropriately. Our Trust's aim is to confirm that this remarkable bird still exists. We need you all to be our eyes and ears.

Any evidence provided will be considered by the South Island Kokako Charitable Trust and independent expert confirmation of the bird's existence in the field will be sought before

the reward is paid. As evidence, the Trust would prefer a verifiable photograph of the bird but will consider other compelling evidence.

If you hear the South Island kokako, it is so distinctively different, it will stop you in your tracks. Even so, the song of a tui has been known to come close. Sound recordings have yet to provide the evidence we need so now we're appealing to back country users to find the proof.

The Trust is inviting you to record possible encounters through its website. It has already received encouraging reports over the past few years and from these has produced a map of sites where South Island kokako are most likely to be found. The map and further information about the search and the reward is available on the Trust's website www.southislandkokako.org.

Wellington Section 2017 contacts list

We are always thankful for volunteers and members stepping forward to help the section run smoothly. If you'd like to learn more about how you could get involved, please email us at wellington@alpineclub.org.nz

Position	Name	Contact
Chairperson	Simon Williamson	021 054 7684
Co Chair	Eric Duggan	021 350 161
Treasurer (Acting)	Peter Laurenson	
Secretary & Vertigo editor	Carolyn Ellis	021 574 287
Patron	John Nankervis	
Other Committee Members	Elisha Watson	
	Matt Pemberton	
	Sandy Britain	
	Alex Waterford	
	Michael Neely	
Rock Drill Overseer	Jeremy Tries	027 55 55 893

www.facebook.com/nzacwellington

Twitter @NZACWellington



Shed 6 Queens Wharf
Wellingtons Waterfront
Ph 04 4998898 Fax 04 4998896
wn@fergskayaks.co.nz
www.fergskayaks.co.nz

Open 7 Days

Largest Real Rock Indoor Rock Wall – Kayaking – Inline Skates – Retail – Rental

Alpine Club members can climb any time for \$12
Monday nights show your Alpine Club card and climb for \$10

New routes every week*

\$1000 worth of new holds in Jan/Feb 2012

New pad in "Da Cave" allowing safe aggressive bouldering

Creating happiness through
better climbing

* to be precise, this is just an average but we do aim for new routes every single week.



**HangDog Rock Climbing
Adventures**

453 Hutt Rd
Lower Hutt
(04) 589 9181
info@hangdog.co.nz

www.hangdog.co.nz

i climb
.co.nz

Simond alpine equipment direct from the importer



Ocelot
\$115



MXC 820
\$230



Makalu
\$255



Caiman
\$230

all crampons include anti-balling plates
and crampon bag



i climb
.co.nz